at the University of California, Berkeley, wrote in his 1968 review of Lamb's monumental, two-volume work *The McMahon Line: A Study in the Relations Between India, China, and Tibet, 1904 to 1914*, 'The line between scholarly objectivity and special pleading is per-force a narrower one when the subject is a current political controversy, as this study amply indicates'. There is no doubt, Rose wrote, that Lamb's works

> constitute a statement of the Chinese position in the current dispute with India over their eastern Himalayan border. This is not unwelcome. The Chinese do have a case, and Mr. Lamb presents it in much clearer and persuasive terms than the Peking [Beijing] Government. The non-specialist reader, unfamiliar with this little-known border area, should be fully aware of the author's particular bias in evaluating his analysis of events and conclusions.[24]

In my view, Lamb's near-obsession with map details and minor issues relating to border demarcation also clouds the broader, geopolitical picture. The more I studied the issue, the clearer it became that it was indeed much more than a border dispute—and that the Chinese never intended to hold on to the territory they captured during the war, areas they claimed as theirs.

The Chinese withdrawal from the occupied areas in 1962 has actually puzzled many military historians and others, who have speculated that it was the approaching winter or the long supply lines from the rear that had halted the advance. Despite those difficulties, the Chinese could actually have pushed down even further, to Assam proper and the Brahmaputra plain, where the weather would not have been a problem and food was in abundance. They could easily have captured Tezpur, a town just south of the mountains with an excellent airport, which the Indian military and the local administration had wholly abandoned.

The development of the Chinese air force began in earnest after the Korean War in the early 1950s, and by the time of the war with India, China had thousands of aircraft, including transport planes. Some were imported from the Soviet Union, while others were copies manufactured under licence in China.[25] Although there is no indication that the Chinese in 1962 had deployed aircraft to Tibet (which, at that time, had only five operational airports), or that the People's Liberation Air Force was suffering from an acute shortage of pilots, US intelligence believed that '[i]f the Chinese Air Force were able to operate from Burma, or were able to seize airfields in the Brahmaputra Valley, its capability would be greatly enhanced'.[26] It would also have been possible to use airfields in China's